

## Q What can I expect in the neonatal intensive unit?

As a parent, it's natural to feel anxious and scared when you see your baby in an incubator, with tubes attached and hooked up to lots of machines. However, all of the equipment in the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) is there to help your baby breathe and keep him nourished to ensure he develops and grows so that in time he can manage on his own.



**Support** Babies who are born prematurely may spend time in an incubator. These are similar to usual hospital cribs, but have a lid to keep your baby warm. Holes in the sides allow you to reach in to touch and caress your baby.



**Pads** These may be attached to your baby's chest and connect to the monitors beside his crib, providing readings for heart rate, blood pressure, oxygen levels, and temperature. These monitors might beep quite often, which can sound alarming. Ask a nurse to explain what it all means if you're worried.

**Feeding tube** Your baby may have a feeding tube inserted into his nose or mouth. This is used when he is still too tiny to breast-feed or receive milk via a bottle.

**Ventilator** Your baby will probably be on a ventilator. There are several kinds, ranging from ones that feed the lungs oxygen-rich air through a tube in the mouth or nose, and remove carbon dioxide, to a high-frequency ventilator, which blows short, rapid puffs of air into your baby's lungs.

**Goggles** Lighting in the neonatal intensive care unit (NICU) can be very bright to enable the staff to work. Very premature babies may be given goggles to protect their sensitive eyes and help them to sleep undisturbed by light.

## Q How will my baby be taken care of in the NICU?

**Your baby will receive around-the-clock care, specially tailored for his specific circumstances. NICU nurses will take care of your baby every minute of the day and night, with one nurse specially assigned to your baby's care.** In addition to the nurses, pediatricians with expertise not just in premature babies, but also in the specific issues relating to your baby, will take care of him. For example, if your baby is showing signs of neurological damage, a neurologist will take care of this aspect of his care. Your baby will also be assigned to a neonatologist (a doctor specializing in the

complex needs of special-care babies) and to a social worker, who will support you through your baby's time in the NICU. Other relevant specialists and nurses will also all be on hand to make sure that your baby receives the best care possible.

## Q Can I talk to the staff at any time about my baby's progress, and can I help with his care?

**The NICU nurses are always on hand to talk to, and they will encourage you to ask questions and, when possible, to help with tasks such as washing and changing your baby.** If you have

any questions that the nurses can't answer, they will ensure that the appropriate doctor or other clinician contacts you as soon as possible to talk to you. You should find that the doctors taking care of your baby are happy to have an open and supportive dialogue about his care, and you should feel involved in all the decisions that need to be made about his care. If you're worried or confused about anything and want a layperson's view, ask your social worker to put you in touch with other parents who have been through similar experiences. One of the best ways to get involved in your baby's care, and to get to know the medical staff who takes care of him, is to be there when the doctors visit him—the nurses can tell you at what time each day this is likely to be.